force all information to flow through the centre, or to prevent people from talking with one another, criticising him or organising against him.[20]

In the millennia following the agricultural revolution, and especially after writing helped create large bureaucratic polities, it became easier to centralise the flow of information and harder to maintain the democratic conversation. In small city-states like those of ancient Mesopotamia and Greece, autocrats like Lugal-Zagesi of Umma and Pisistratus of Athens relied on bureaucrats, archives and a standing army to monopolise key economic assets and information about ownership, taxation, diplomacy and politics. It simultaneously became harder for the mass of citizens to keep in direct touch with one another. There was no mass communication technology like newspapers or radio, and it was not easy to squeeze tens of thousands of citizens into the main city square to hold a communal discussion.

Democracy was still an option for these small city-states, as the history of both early Sumer and classical Greece clearly indicates.[21] However, the democracy of ancient city-states tended to be less inclusive than the democracy of archaic hunter-gatherer bands. Probably the most famous example of ancient city-state democracy is Athens in the fifth and fourth centuries BCE. All adult male citizens could participate in the Athenian assembly, vote on public policy and be elected to public offices. But women, slaves and non-citizen residents of the city did not enjoy these privileges. Only about 25–30 per cent of the adult population of Athens enjoyed full political rights.[22]

As the size of polities continued to increase, and city-states were superseded by larger kingdoms and empires, even Athenian-style partial democracy disappeared. All the famous examples of ancient democracies are city-states such as Athens and Rome. In contrast, we don’t know of any large-scale kingdom or empire that operated along democratic lines.

For example, when in the fifth century BCE Athens expanded from a city-state into an empire, it did not grant citizenship and political rights to those it conquered. The city of Athens remained a limited democracy, but the much bigger Athenian Empire was ruled autocratically from the centre. All the important decisions about taxes, diplomatic alliances and military expeditions were taken in Athens. Subject lands like the islands of Naxos and Thasos had to obey the orders of the Athenian popular assembly and elected officials, without the Naxians and Thasians being able to vote in